IT Support Terminology Glossary

Essential Terms for Upcoming IT Support Superstars

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Introduction

Here are some common terms used in the course you may not be familiar with, but are important to learn as an upcoming IT Support superstar!

Core IT Support Terms

Proactive vs Reactive Support

Proactive Taking preventative actions to address potential issues before they escalate into problems.

Example: Regularly updating software and monitoring system performance to prevent future issues.

Reactive Responding to issues and problems as they occur, often in real-time.

Example: Fixing a computer after it crashes or addressing a network outage when users report it.

User and Service Management

End Users

Individuals who use the products or services provided by the IT department, such as employees within the organization.

Examples: Office workers using computers, managers accessing databases, or customers using company applications.

Ticket/Ticketing System

A record of an issue or request for assistance submitted by an end user, typically managed through a ticketing system for tracking and resolution.

Purpose: Organizes support requests, tracks progress, and ensures nothing gets overlooked.

SLA (Service Level Agreement)

A formal agreement between the IT department and end users, specifying the level of service, response times, and other metrics.

Example: "Critical issues will be responded to within 30 minutes, resolved within 4 hours."

Issue Management Process

Incident

An unplanned interruption or reduction in the quality of a service, such as a system outage or software malfunction.

Examples: Email server down, website not loading, printer not working, or software crashing.

Resolution

The successful conclusion or fix for an incident or request, often documented in the ticketing system.

Goal: Restore normal service operation and prevent recurrence when possible.

Escalation

The process of transferring a ticket or issue to a higher level of support or management for resolution, typically due to complexity or urgency.

When to escalate: Issue beyond your skill level, high business impact, or approaching SLA deadlines.

Knowledge and Documentation

Knowledge Base

A centralized repository of articles, guides, and documentation containing solutions to common issues and best practices for troubleshooting.

Benefits: Faster resolution times, consistent solutions, and self-service options for users.

Quick Reference

Term	Definition	Key Point
Proactive	Preventing issues before they occur	Prevention is better than cure
Reactive	Responding to issues as they happen	Fixing problems after they occur
End Users	People who use IT services	Your customers and stakeholders
Ticket	Record of a support request	Tracks and organizes all issues
SLA	Service commitment agreement	Defines expectations and timelines
Incident	Unplanned service interruption	What you're called to fix
Resolution	Successfully fixing the problem	The goal of every ticket
Escalation	Passing issue to higher support	When you need additional help
Knowledge Base	Repository of solutions	Your first stop for answers

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Why These Terms Matter

Understanding this terminology is crucial for IT support success because:

- **Communication** - Speak the same language as your team and users
- **Professional Growth** - Demonstrate knowledge and competence
- **Efficiency** - Use proper processes and tools effectively
- **Career Development** - Foundation for advancing in IT support roles

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Remember: Mastering these terms is your first step toward becoming an IT Support superstar!

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